



Asia Pacific Internet Governance Academy Nepal 2026

Information Kit for Model ICANN Conference & Preparation Sessions

This is an information kit that will help you get prepared for the Model ICANN conference at APIGA Nepal 2026. This document includes information and details about the topics, the format of the preparation sessions and the role-play discussion etc.

This Document has been referenced from Asia Pacific Internet Governance Academy (APIGA) 2022 model ICANN conference guidebook and has been modified for APIGA Nepal 2026.

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Background

When the digital world has become a parallel world, the protection of digital citizens is crucial to prevent abuse. Threatening digital space security is a kind of threat to the digital citizen who is relying on it. In 2010, Registration Abuse Policies Working Group (RAPWG) published its Final Report which stated that there was abuse harming the DNS infrastructure or using DNS to cause harm and issued its recommendations. (ICANNWiki). Since then, DNS Abuse has been one of the big discussion topics among policymakers.

The role of ICANN & DNS abuse

Internet Corporation for Assigned Names and Numbers ("ICANN") is in charge of ensuring the stable and secure operation of the Internet's unique identifier systems. It does that in several ways. ICANN relies on the tech community to review policy and other decisions for potential security and stability issues. Its Technology Office monitors gTLD zone files for DNS Abuse and reports on that abuse. ICANN contracts with registries and registrars too, respectively, to monitor and address DNS Abuse to ensure that registries and registrars actively participate in this function, and it enforces those contracts through its Compliance Office. However, the landscape shifted significantly on April 5, 2024, with global amendments to the Registrar Accreditation Agreement (RAA) and Base Generic Top-Level Domain Registry Agreement (RA). Registrars and registries are now contractually obligated to promptly stop or otherwise disrupt domains when they possess actionable evidence of DNS abuse.

While ICANN plays an important role in the mitigation of DNS Abuse, it has consistently made clear that it is not a regulator of website content. ICANN has stated that the ICANN is not responsible for making factual and legal determinations of whether content violates the law. ICANN cannot be put in the position of requiring suspension of domain names on the basis of allegations of blasphemy, hate speech, political organizing, full or partial nudity, or a host of other content that may be illegal somewhere in the world. That would be inconsistent with ICANN's mission, limited remit, and responsibility to operate in accordance with a consensus-driven multistakeholder model.

Although ICANN is not authorized to regulate activities that fall outside its clearly defined mission, it serves a critical role in contributing to multistakeholder community efforts by providing a discussion forum during its meetings and the opportunity to engage broadly within the community. Registrars and registries welcome the continued dialogue on this issue in hopes of raising the bar for responsible and thoughtful stewardship of the DNS. (ICANN, 2019)

Addressing DNS abuse

The most common definition means domains registered for phishing, malware, botnets, and domains advertised in spam. These activities are commonly recognized in most countries and jurisdictions as illegal or at least harmful. Many Internet stakeholders consider other types of domain misuse just as abusive, and in some cases just as illegal (Young, 2014). The 2024 contractual amendments established a firm definition aligning with this, explicitly categorizing DNS abuse as malware, botnets, phishing, pharming, and spam (when used to deliver the other four forms).

Generic Top-Level Domain (gTLD) registries and registrars are required by the agreements with ICANN to maintain abuse contacts to receive abuse complaints and to promptly investigate allegations of DNS Abuse in

good faith. In addition, each of the undersigned disrupts DNS Abuse when identified within our registrations and encourages others to do the same. Because of its role in the DNS, the only mitigation tool a registry or registrar possesses is to disable the entire domain name. Registries and registrars do not have the ability to surgically target the "abusive parts" of a domain name or a particular page on that domain. Unfortunately, disabling a domain name is as powerful as it is imprecise, especially when the DNS Abuse occurs on a broader platform, forum, marketplace, or other domain shared by large audiences.

A registry or registrar should act to disrupt the following forms of Website Content Abuse: (1) child sexual abuse materials ("CSAM"); (2) illegal distribution of opioids online; (3) human trafficking;¹⁰ and (4) specific and credible incitements to violence. Underlying these Website Content Abuses is a physical and often irreversible threat to human life. Additionally, each registrar and registry has its own acceptable use policies or terms of use that set forth provisions that may cover these and additional forms of Website Content Abuses. (DNS Abuse Framework, 2020)

Should ICANN take action?

Should ICANN act as an internet content regulator for the purpose of minimizing DNS abuse? If so, would they be acting outside their mission statement that "ICANN shall not regulate (i.e., impose rules and restrictions on) services that use the Internet's unique identifiers or the content....?" Is mandating the power to the law enforcers the best way to minimize DNS abuse? Should there be a one-size-fits-all regulator that regulates the operation of the Internet's unique identifier as well as maintains stability of the Internet's unique identifier?

DNS Abuse

DNS abuse refers to the intentional misuse of the Domain Name System (DNS) to carry out malicious activities on the internet. The DNS is the system that translates human-readable domain names (like example.com) into IP addresses that computers use to communicate with each other. When DNS is abused, it can facilitate various forms of cybercrime.

- **Phishing:** Creating fraudulent websites that mimic legitimate ones to trick users into providing sensitive information, such as passwords or credit card numbers.
- **Malware Distribution:** Using domains to host or distribute malicious software designed to harm devices, steal data, or spy on users.
- **Botnets:** Using compromised domains to control networks of infected computers (bots) that can be used to launch attacks like Distributed Denial of Service (DDoS).
- **Spam:** Sending unsolicited bulk messages that often contain malicious links or attachments. Domains may be registered specifically to send out these messages.
- **Pharming:** Redirecting users from legitimate websites to fraudulent ones without their knowledge, often to steal personal information.
- **DNS Hijacking:** Altering DNS settings to redirect traffic to malicious sites or to intercept data.

Model ICANN conference

A fundamental part of ICANN's Mission is to coordinate policy development related to the Internet's system of unique identifiers. DNS Policies are developed through formal policy development processes (PDPs), as set forth by the ICANN Bylaws.

Policy recommendations are developed and refined by the ICANN Community through its Supporting Organisations (SOs) and influenced by Advisory Committees (ACs) – all composed of volunteers from across the world – in a "bottom-up", open and transparent process. Each Supporting Organisation has its own specific policy development process. (ICANN, n.d.)

Problem Statement

DNS Abuse is any malicious activity aimed at disrupting the DNS infrastructure or causing the DNS to operate in an unintended manner, which includes malware, botnets, phishing, harming, and spam when it serves as the delivery mechanism for DNS Abuse. Phishing occurs when an attacker tricks a victim into revealing sensitive personal, corporate, or financial information, whether through sending fraudulent or "look-alike" emails or luring end-users to copycat websites. Some phishing campaigns aim to persuade the user to install software, which is in fact malware.

At the implementation level, however, the reality is that we are still stuck in the first hurdle in grappling with the basic notion of DNS abuse, which renders all users susceptible to any form of DNS abuse particularly phishing during the COVID-19 pandemic. To date, there is no universal framework to combat the latest trend of phishing attacks as threat actors have successfully deployed various DNS-based attacks against company networks and individuals over the years.

The ICANN community has undertaken different endeavours in defining DNS abuse. What is common is that all stakeholder groups agree that this is an issue of importance.

GAC, as the government entirely agrees with solving the issues concerning DNS abuse. The GAC community is uniquely positioned to assess and choose what policies should be taken to safeguard the public from DNS abuse by having law enforcement and regulatory bodies gain access to the contact information of victims as well as bad actors.

Meanwhile, GNSO explained that there are three separate, sequential efforts, either narrowly scoped efforts or PDPs, for mitigating malicious registrations; (a) Malicious Registrations used for the distribution of Malware; (b) Malicious Registrations used for Phishing; and (c) Malicious Registrations used for the operation of Botnet command and control systems.

ALAC believes that DNS Abuse is one of the biggest challenges faced by individual Internet end users and remains a key factor eroding confidence in a single, trusted, interoperable Internet.

Statement 1: What is your stakeholder group's agreed definition of 'DNS abuse'?

Statement 2: What is your stakeholder group's expectation of ICANN's role in DNS abuse?

While we are trying to come up with a Consensus with the community, there are three possible arguments that usually come to the discussion table when we try to tackle with DNS abuse.

- **Argument 1: Should ICANN be responsible for putting these policies in place?**
- **Argument 2: Prioritizing new Generic top-level domains (gTLDs) over introducing DNS Abuse policies**
 - The New gTLD Program: 2026 Round application window officially closed on August 12, 2026, receiving over 1,600 applications. As the community anticipates 'Reveal Day' in October 2026 to review the applied-for strings, the debate has shifted. The focus is no longer on delaying the application launch, but on how to enforce DNS abuse mitigation before these newly proposed strings are delegated to the root zone.
- **Argument 3: The WHOIS privacy issue**
 - Privacy issues on WHOIS remain a significant concern due to the redaction of personally identifiable information (PII) following GDPR. However, the debate advanced with the implementation of the Registration Data Policy on August 21, 2025. This consensus policy replaced the interim policy, creating a permanent framework for how domain registration data is collected and published. Discussions should now focus on navigating this established framework rather than debating the initial redaction.

Guiding Questions for discussion on Day 1 preparation session

1. What types of DNS Abuse frequently happen in your country? How is DNS abuse regulated in your country?
2. The ignorance on the part of the user is one of the reasons why phishing during the COVID-19 pandemic is championed by the attackers. From end-users perspectives, how can you mitigate phishing attacks?
3. The attacker's continually adapt to the newest trends of abusing the Domain Name System. What are the cyber security defenses that the ICANN and the community can employ in order to efficaciously combat phishing attacks?
4. What are ICANN's scope of operations and limitations in minimizing DNS Abuse?

Format of preparation session & model ICANN conference

DAY 1 - SEPTEMBER 5TH

Team Building (20 mins)

Participants will be divided into 3 groups and form their group name.

- ICANN role-play - Preparation
Facilitator will introduce the format of the role-play discussion and prep sessions. Participants will be split into 3 groups, i.e. GAC, GNSO and ALAC. The session will be run in breakout group discussion format.
- Participants will break out into groups - GAC, GNSO and ALAC - to research on topics and stakeholder's position.
- To prepare for role-play discussion, research definitions, how different groups define them, and their positions.
- Participants have to choose a chair, vice-chair and rapporteurs for their respective groups. These roles will play a significant role in a particular session in the Model ICANN conference.

Agenda

- Recap of ICANN Community & Multistakeholder model (10 mins)
- Role-play preparation (5 mins)
- Wrap-up (5 mins)

DAY 2 - SEPTEMBER 6TH

(1) Preparation for the ICANN Model Conference

Agenda

- Recap basics of DNS abuse (5 mins)
- Brainstorming DNS abuse (20 mins)

To discuss the specific issue of DNS abuse. Each group will be discussing DNS abuse, concepts, and issues.

Agenda

- Briefing (10 mins)
Facilitators will revise the following items with the participants:
 - What is Model ICANN Conference?
 - ICANN by-laws and how the policy development process works
 - The participants' roles in the Model ICANN Conference
- Preparation by participants (20 mins)
 - Participants will prepare final statements for their Model ICANN Conference based on their roles.

- Mentors and facilitators will assist participants in each group.
- Presentation from each stakeholder group (5 minutes)
 - Open floor (10 mins)
- In-group discussion (25 mins)
 - Each stakeholder group discusses the topic among themselves.
 - To digest statements of other groups and adjust positions.

(2) Model ICANN Conference Part 2

Agenda - Role-play discussion

- Cross-community breakout discussion (30 mins)
 - To find Consensus on both problem statements.
 - Groupings:
 - GAC (Chair + 1h group mates) and ALAC (Chair + 1h group mates)
 - GAC (Vice Chair + 1h group mates) and GNSO (Chair + 1h group mates)
 - ALAC (Vice Chair + 1h group mates) and GNSO (Vice Chair + 1h group mates)
- Working Coffee Break
 - Everyone can move freely to chat with each other one-on-one to get information about their discussion on DNS abuse.
- In-group discussion (25 mins)
 - Chair / Vice-Chair to give on update on cross-community breakout discussion
 - Members to give on update on important information retrieved from working coffee break
 - Adjusting and prepare final statements
- Plenary (30 mins)
 - Regroup. Closing & Consensus statement
 - Each stakeholder group is to present its updated statement and position on the discussion.
 - The Chair will observe whether the conversation has progressed, and will try to lead to a Consensus.
 - Open floor.
- Wrap-up (10 mins)

Agenda - Learning & takeaways

- Sharing their experience about Model ICANN conference (15 mins)
 - Each group will have 5 mins to share their experience
- Participants Feedback to the organizer team (15 mins)
 - Open floor to participants

For program details about other sessions at APIGA 2026, you may go to www.apiga.org.np

Instructions on roles & responsibilities

This section can provide you with some insights about your roles and responsibilities as chairs, vice-chair or note takers during the Model ICANN conference.

Governmental Advisory Committee (GAC)

Role assignment.

Organize your group to take on the following roles*:

**Important – Group Leaders cannot take on the positions of Chair/Vice-Chair. Someone must volunteer; barring none, you have the power to nominate.*

GAC Chair The Chair's role will be to formulate (and decide) GAC's positions on the various problem statements. The Chair will also represent GAC in 'breakout' conversations with the other groups' chairs. They will nominate a spokesperson to speak on behalf of GAC during the plenary.	GAC vice Chair The Vice Chair's role is to assist the Chair. The Vice-Chair will also be able to Represent GAC in 'breakout' conversations (you will have concurrent breakout sessions with ALAC and GNSO)
2 x Note takers Note takers have the important task of noting the statements/positions of the other groups. This is a crucial task as your group will need to know whether you share the same position with other Groups, or that your Chair/Vice-Chair will need to find Consensus with them. They should prepare a Google doc and share their screen during your in-group discussions	The rest of the members Those who did not volunteer any of the above roles will thus be volunteer to be spokespersons for the group. GAC spokespersons will have to introduce themselves as GAC reps of specific countries (e.g. I'm John the GAC rep of Japan).

Formulate your positions

Assist your Chair/Vice-Chair to formulate GAC's positions for the following:

- **Problem Statement: What is your stakeholder groups agreed definition of 'DNS abuse'?**
 - Tip: When making your statements in Plenary – cite some examples so other groups can understand exactly what you mean (e.g. you and I may not share the same definition of the term "malware")
 - Refer to GAC's statement on DNS abuse. Also see this presentation which GAC referred to definitions in previous GAC advice and other work groups.
- **What is GAC's baseline position of the above definition?**
 - You need to find Consensus on the definition with other groups by finding common ground. Establish early on whether you are willing to forgo your stated definition to adopt that of others; or that your position is to 'force' others to adopt yours.

- Tip: GAC's position is unique because often you need to achieve consensus within the GAC before putting forward a position. You can choose to assume you have consensus in the GAC and put something forward; or put forward that you have no consensus and therefore choose no position.
- **Problem Statement: What is your stakeholder group's expectation of ICANN's role in DNS abuse?**
 - Tip: Refer to the above-provided links. The GAC will want to ensure that ICANN works within its Bylaws so have this ready.
 - You can add other expectations as you see fit – they can be used as 'bargaining' chips.
- **What is GAC's baseline position regarding the policy questions above?**
 - Formulate your position early. Establish early on whether you are willing to forgo some expectations to find common ground. Or you can adopt a position to 'force' others to adopt your expectations.
 - Evaluate whether the finalized 2025 Registration Data Policy effectively balances law enforcement access needs with the codified global privacy regulations.

Generic Names Supporting Organization (GNSO)

Role assignment.

Organize your group to take on the following roles*:

**Important – Group Leaders cannot take on the positions of Chair/Vice Chair. Someone must volunteer; barring none you will have the power to nominate.*

GNSO Chair The Chair's role will be to formulate (and decide) GNSO's positions to the various problem statements. They will also represent GNSO in 'breakout' conversations with the other groups' chairs. They will nominate the spokesperson to speak on behalf of GNSO during the Plenary.	GNSO Vice Chair The Vice Chair's role is to assist the Chair. The Vice Chair will also be able to represent GNSO in 'breakout' conversations (you will have concurrent breakout sessions with ALAC and GAC)
2 x Notetakers Notetakers have the important task of noting the statements/positions of the other groups. This is a crucial task as your group will need to know whether you share the same position with other groups, or that your Chair/Vice Chair will need to find consensus with them. They should prepare a Google doc and share their screen during your in-group discussions	The rest of the members Those who did not volunteer any of the above roles will thus be "voluntold" to be spokespersons for the group.

Formulate your positions

Assist your Chair/Vice Chair to formulate GNSO's positions for the following:

- **Problem Statement: What is your stakeholder group's unanimous definition of 'DNS abuse'?**

- Tip: When making your statements in Plenary – cite some examples so other groups can understand exactly what you mean (e.g. you and I may not share the same definition of the term "malware")
- CENTR has a good blog of DNS abuse highlighting the overall situation. The voice of the Contracted Parties is strong in the GNSO and may guide your position - refer to the mention of Contracted Parties' definition of 'DNS abuse'.
- **What is GNSO's baseline position of the above definition?**
 - You need to find consensus on the definition with other groups by finding common ground. Establish early on whether you are willing to forgo your stated definition to adopt that of others; or that your position is to 'force' others to adopt yours.
- **Problem Statement: What is your stakeholder group's expectation of ICANN's role in DNS abuse?**
 - Tip: Refer to the ICANN72 session on DNS abuse. The overall theme is industry self regulation rather than having 'regulation' stated in the ICANN contracts with registries and registrars. With the 2024 RAA and RA amendments enforcing mandatory mitigation, contracted parties must now focus on preventing collateral damage and managing the operational realities of these active compliance requirements.
 - You can add other expectations as you see fit – they can be used as 'bargaining chips'.
- **What is GNSO's baseline position regarding the policy questions above?**
 - Formulate your position early. Establish early on whether you are willing to forgo some expectations to find common ground. Or you can adopt a position to 'force' others to adopt your expectations.

At-Large Advisory Committee (ALAC)

Role assignment.

Organize your group to take on the following roles:

**Important – Group Leaders cannot take on the positions of Chair/Vice Chair. Someone must volunteer; barring none you will have the power to nominate.*

ALAC Chair The Chair's role will be to formulate (and decide) ALAC's positions to the various problem statements. The Chair will also represent ALAC in 'breakout' conversations with the other groups' chairs. They will nominate the spokesperson to speak on behalf of ALAC during the Plenary.	ALAC Vice Chair The Vice Chair's role is to assist the Chair. The Vice Chair will also be able to represent ALAC in 'breakout' conversations (you will have concurrent breakout sessions with GNSO and GAC)
2 x Notetakers Notetakers have the important task of noting the statements/positions of the other groups. This is a crucial task as your group will need to know whether	The rest of the members Those who did not volunteer any of the above roles will thus be "voluntold" to be spokespersons for the group during Plenary.

you share the same position with other groups, or that your Chair/Vice Chair will need to find consensus with them. They should prepare a Google doc and share their screen during your in-group discussions	
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Formulate your positions

Assist your Chair/Vice-Chair to formulate ALAC's positions for the following:

- **Problem Statement: What is your stakeholder group's agreed definition of 'DNS abuse'?**
 - Tip: When making your statements in Plenary – cite some examples so other groups can understand exactly what you mean (e.g. you and I may not share the same definition of the term "malware")
 - See ALAC's advice to the ICANN board on this topic for reference.
- **What is ALAC's baseline position of the above definition?**
 - You need to find consensus on the definition with other groups by finding common ground. Establish early on whether you are willing to forgo your stated definition to adopt that of others; or that your position is to 'force' others to adopt yours.
 - Tip: ALAC's approach is to refer to definitions used by experts or review groups.
- **Problem Statement: What is your stakeholder group's expectation of ICANN's role in DNS abuse?**
 - Tip: This is in the aforementioned ALAC advice.
 - You can add other expectations as you see fit – they can be used as 'bargaining chips'.
- **What is ALAC's baseline position regarding the policy questions above?**
 - Formulate your position early. Establish early on whether you are willing to forgo some expectations to find common ground. Or you can adopt a position to 'force' others to adopt your expectations.
 - Assess whether the 2024 contractual obligations for registrars and registries are sufficiently protecting end-users and measurably reducing systemic abuse.

Role Description

Each participant will be assigned a role under one of the following stakeholder groups – GAC, GNSO or At-Large. Participants may play the role assigned for the preparation sessions and roleplay discussion for the Model ICANN conference. The following descriptions aim to provide you a better understanding on the stand of your role in the topic of DNS Abuse, so as to help you to come up with better viewpoints when we discuss the mitigation of DNS Abuse with other stakeholders at the Model ICANN conference.

Governmental Advisory Committee (GAC)

GAC serves as the voice of Governments & International Governmental Organisations. The key role of GAC is to provide advice to ICANN on issues of public policy, especially where there is an interaction between ICANN's activities or policies and international agreements or national laws. GAC will discuss Issues with the ICANN

Board and other ICANN supporting organisations, advisory committees and other groups and deliver regular advice.

GAC works to examine a range of issues related to the functions and responsibilities of ICANN. The members have to use the information to develop policy positions within their own administrations. GAC may have to try to reach a consensus position on particular matters and GAC usually provides advice to the ICANN Board when they have reached a consensus view.

There are many organisations outside of the ICANN multi-stakeholder structure that contribute to the policies, governance and functioning of the internet. The GAC and other ICANN constituents frequently collaborate and liaise with these organisations to execute its mission, which is to coordinate the stable operation of the Internet's unique identifier systems.

United States of America

You are the representative of the United States National Telecommunications and Information Administration (NTIA). NTIA represents the U.S. government in ICANN's Governmental Advisory Committee (GAC), which is structured to provide advice to the ICANN Board on the public policy aspects of the broad range of issues pending before ICANN. NTIA is the Executive Branch agency that is principally responsible for advising the President on telecommunications and information policy issues. NTIA's programs and policymaking focus largely on expanding broadband Internet access and adoption in America, expanding the use of spectrum by all users, and ensuring that the Internet remains an engine for continued innovation and economic growth. While the NTIA already transitioned the oversight of Internet Assigned Numbers Authority (IANA) functions to a multi stakeholder body, i.e. Public Technical Identifiers (PTI), it is still heavily involved in the operations of the Internet with its active role in ICANN and other bodies. A significant number of new gTLD applications are also from American organisations.

Position 1: Multistakeholder approach should be adopted in solving DNS Abuse.

Position 2: With over 1,600 applications already submitted for the 2026 round, stringent DNS abuse mitigation frameworks must be finalized and enforced before any of these new strings are officially delegated.

China

You are a delegate of the Ministry of Industry & Information Technology (MIIT). With over 1 billion Internet users and the ever-growing Internet population and economy, the Chinese government is now actively involved in the process of Internet Governance, such as the launching and fast track of Internationalised Domain Names (IDN). You are keen to promote the China marketplace and at the same time ensure necessary policies are in place for security and protect local players. For instance, China issued a policy to require new gTLD operators to localise data storage in order to obtain operating licence in China.

Position 1: China's government believes in a government-driven multilateral model. Governments should be the ones to regulate the Internet space with their own laws.

Position 2: No significant stand on whether the new round of gTLDs come before or after the mitigation of DNS abuse.

European Commission

You are the representative of the European Commission. Acting as the executive of the European Union, you can propose legislation and laws to the EU parliament. Any new gTLDs that violate the interests of your member states are of your concern. The European Commission recently pays concern on the trademark issues regarding the new gTLDs, the community TLDs for example ".vin", and also the financial and security risks of some new gTLDs such as ".bank" and ".fin", etc. You believe safeguards shall be in place to ensure the operators are in compliance. You also doubt the role of GAC in opposing ICANN's policy.

Position 1: The EU Commission is keen to introduce legislation if ICANN is not taking any further action to tackle DNS abuse.

Position 2: Mitigation of DNS Abuse should be in place before new gTLDs

Kenya

You are the representative of Kenya Network Information Centre (KENIC). The domain registry is to operate .ke and related ccTLDs. It also engages in improving the internet related service in Kenya, while the internet penetration stands at more than 82% in the region. You are active in promoting and enhancing the participation from African stakeholders and therefore in favour of policies that can help to create more local operators on the new gTLDs and other related Internet services.

Position 1: Kenya is agnostic on ICANN position, they slightly slide with China on this issue.

Position 2: Now that the 2026 application window has closed, the evaluation and delegation of the pending new gTLDs must proceed without being delayed by DNS abuse policy debates, as these domains present critical growth opportunities for the African region.

Argentina

You are a delegate of NIC Argentina. As the first network communication in the country, it manages the domain name registration and ensures the operation of the Domain Name System for the ccTLD '.ar' is well-maintained. Starting from November this year, the domain '.com.ar' will be available to all users in NIC Argentina which does not require prior authorizations. You are very concerned with the new gTLD '.amazon' applied by Amazon.com Inc, which is one of your rainforests in Latin America. Therefore you have allied with a number of Latin American GAC representatives to object to the applications.

Japan

You are a delegate of the Ministry of Internal Affairs and Communications. The Ministry oversees the Japanese administrative system, manages local governments, elections, telecommunication, post, and governmental statistics. You are actively involved with the IDNs policy development as Japanese in general prefer to use local language to communicate rather than English.

Position 1: ICANN should create policies to address DNS abuse.

Position 2: Japan is quite active on DNS abuse, specifically regarding piracy of manga and comics online in recent years. It is different to take down pirate Manga sites since TLD hopping is quite common.

United Kingdom

You are a delegate of the Global Internet Governance Policy, the United Kingdom. Child protection has long been advocated in the UK. The UK Council for Child Internet Safety (UKCCIS) is a group of more than 200 organisations drawn from across government, industry, law, academia and charity sectors that work in partnership to help keep children safe online. There are concerns whether the use of some new gTLDs like .kids might harm children's benefits and online safety and also believe safeguards shall be in place.

Privacy issue on WHOIS is also a big concern to the UK. In the past, you can obtain most information of a registered domain name, including registrant's phone numbers, addresses, and other personally identifiable information (PII) from the WHOIS database. Patterns of DNS abuses have become harder to identify due to the redaction of PII from the WHOIS database after the implementation of policies such as GDPR.

Position 1: UK is keen on the technical component, such as maintaining security and civility of the Internet.

Position 2: UK also highlighted GDPR for the discussion on the WHOIS issues.

South Korea

You are a delegate of the Korean Internet Security Agency (KISA) in which Korean ccTLDs are under the control and management of the KISA. Resolution of conflicts over domain names. As a Deputy General Researcher of the KRNIC Policy Team at the KISA and acts as the Republic of Korea (RoK)'s official representative of the GAC to ICANN, you are contending that the domain dispute should be alleviated in which all domain name registration should be vetted by upholding Uniform Name Dispute Resolution Process (UDRP) instead of being reviewed and decided under Korean law as ruled by the Supreme Court of Korea. Realising this matter, as a representative of the GAC to ICANN, there is a concern vis-a-vis the improvement of UDRP.

Sweden

As a delegation of Swedish registry IIS, you have a concern on whether there is a legal basis for ICANN org to access registration data for purposes of accuracy verification due to the fact that WHOIS data has replaced GDPR's job.

Prior to the GDPR, WHOIS provided access to all available information. And when GDPR came around, ICANN conducted a great deal of effort and received guidance from the Material Protection Board in Europe, which stated that GAC may keep WHOIS, WHOIS records, but cannot reveal all the information, which was referred to as private data in accordance with the Data Protection Board's legal guidance. This indicates that not all information was available to the public. To get this information, one must have a legal basis, and the controller, or contracted party, must conduct a balancing test. The issue arises as GAC cannot verify the

information's accuracy without proof that it is inaccurate. Moreover, the difficulty is that GAC does not know whether the information is accurate because neither ICANN nor GAC are able to validate it.

Position 1: Similar to the UK and US. Sweden is keen on the multistakeholder approach.

Generic Names Supporting Organisation (GNSO)

GNSO recommends changes to policies for gTLDs, such as .com, .org, .biz. GNSO is to keep gTLDs operating in a fair and orderly fashion across one global Internet while promoting innovation and competition. When it comes to the topic of DNS abuse, GNSO usually believes there is no contrast with the launching of new gTLDs, but it is an issue that has to be resolved with all stakeholders.

Most registries and registrars believe they have enough internal policies to deal with DNS abuse, and therefore, ICANN policies on this issue are unnecessary to them. Since DNS abuse mostly relates to content of a particular domain name, where ICANN is in no position to content moderation.

GoDaddy (Registrar)

You are a GoDaddy representative, a domain registrar and a web hosting company. People pay a fee to GoDaddy for the right to use specific second-level domain names, and it manages over 61 million domain names. GoDaddy believes that new gTLDs can help websites stand out from the crowd and hence provide more commercial prospects.

Position 1: There are enough internal policies to deal with DNS abuse. New ICANN policies on DNS abuse do not give any advantages to registrar nor helping with DNS abuse

Position 2: ICANN should only take the advisory position, the market will decide.

Representative of GMO (Registrar)

You are a multibillion-dollar Japanese tech company headquartered in Tokyo that operates a variety of companies, including registry and registrar services. In January, the GMO Registry spent about \$41.5 million in an attempt to obtain the right to resell shop domain names. GMO is the largest Japanese registrar in the domestic market, with plans to grow in Asia and beyond. You are supportive of the introduction of new gTLDs and actively participate in ICANN policymaking.

Representative of Verisign (Registry)

You represent Verisign, an Internet infrastructure service provider which operates multiple domains, such as .com and .net, which held the bulk of market share prior to the introduction of new gTLDs. Verisign operates one of the 13 global Internet root servers. You have raised concerns regarding the security and stability of the domain name system (DNS) in light of the exponential growth of new generic top-level domains (gTLDs). With the recent influx of over 1,600 new applications from the August 2026 application window, your priority is ensuring the root server infrastructure can handle this massive expansion securely.

Position 1: Indifferent towards having ICANN policies to mitigate DNS Abuse. Willing to establish policies to tackle the issue, but prefer enforcement on launching new gTLDs.

Position 2: All TLDs should adhere to the standards of community TLDs.

Representative of Google

You are a Google representative who had invested heavily in the previous round of new gTLDs applications, applying for names such as .google and .android, as well as multiple Internationalised Domain Names (IDNs). Google's large number of applications has encouraged other applicants to jump on board as well, because Google is a world-renowned Internet corporation that understands search, and their actions have ensured that new gTLDs will perform well.

Position 1: ICANN should not overstep.

Position 2: Google has been dealing with the 5 defined types of DNS abuse (i.e. spam, phishing, botnet and malware) already.

Representative of COMMUNITY TLD (.HOTEL)

You are a representative of .HOTEL Top-Level-Domain S.a.r.l., a community TLD applicant for the ".hotel" domain who wins the community priority review and hence the operational rights over the other 6 ".hotel" applicants. You have the endorsement of several hotel coalitions and have a closed registration policy that is limited to hotels, hotel chains, hotel associations, and marketing or other representative organisations that work directly with hotels and hotel chains. The Hotel Consumer Protection Coalition, comprised of over 25,000 hotels in over 100 countries, including many prominent brands, has filed complaints against six of the seven hotel applications, as well as the applications for .hotels, .hoteis, and .hoteles. They backed your application and requested the Independent Objector to object to the other applications on behalf of the community. They intend to file their own Community Objections if this does not happen.

Position 1: More protection should be enforced in order to increase incentives for registrants to choose a community TLD.

Position 2: Existing policies are restrictive for community TLDs anyway, more policies on DNS abuse could be beneficial.

Representative of COMMUNITY TLD (.KIDS)

You are a representative of .kids. It is a community TLD that takes the protection of kids safety and interests with priority, and works closely with the global children's rights and welfare community to put in place relevant policies to mitigate against abuse.

Position 1: Protection of child online safety and interests are always the highest priority.

Position 2: Community should work closely to mitigate the issues related to children's rights and welfare.

NCUC (Noncommercial Users Constituency)

You are an NCUC representative, and your goal is to represent the interests and concerns of non-commercial registrants and non-commercial Internet users of generic Top-level Domains (gTLDs).

Position 1: NCUC prioritizes regulations on content and reverse abuse.

Position 2: NCUC has a concern on the suppression of free speech if new policies were to be implemented.

NPOC (Not-for-Profit Operational Concerns Constituency)

You are a NPOC representative who advocates for not-for-profit entities and NGOs. You seek to offer insights on operational issues such as domain name registration, DNS expansion, fraud and abuse, and the use of the DNS to deliver and collect information and serve their members and communities. You are also interested in human rights concerns, such as child rights and online safety for children.

Position 1: Supportive in having policies on DNS abuse.

Representative of ISP

You are an ISP's representative. ISPs typically provide organisations and/or individuals with Internet connectivity. ISP access services may include web hosting, email, VoIP (voice over IP), and support for a variety of other applications. ISP firmly supports ICANN's efforts to guarantee that the Internet's stability and reliability are not jeopardised by the establishment of new gTLDs. As previously noted, the ISP regards this principle as extremely important.

Position 1: Personally identifiable information (PII) is important in addressing DNS abuse but PII is redacted.

Position 2: Interested in the linkage between GDPR and WHOIS.

GNSO Liaison

You are the liaison of GNSO to GAC. Your role is to provide and share the update information of GNSO to GAC. The GNSO Liaison to the GAC (the Liaison) role was established in 2014 to improve communications between the GNSO and the GAC, and to encourage early engagement by the GAC in policy development processes and other GNSO activities. The Liaison also regularly participates in all GAC meetings held at ICANN involving GNSO-related issues.

At-Large Advisory Committee (ALAC)

The At-Large Advisory Committee (ALAC) is the primary organisational home for the voice and concerns of the individual Internet user. Representing the At-Large Community, the 15-member ALAC consists of two members selected by each of the five Regional At-Large Organisations (RALOs) and five members appointed by ICANN's Nominating Committee.

ALAC is advocating for the interests of end-users, the ALAC advises on the activities of ICANN, including Internet policies developed by ICANN's Supporting Organisations; it also participates in ICANN's outreach and engagement programs. In addition, one At-Large member is selected by the ALAC and the At-Large Community to serve on ICANN's Board of Directors.

Your roles include considering and providing advice on the activities of ICANN as they relate to the interests of individual Internet users. This includes policies created through SOs, as well as ICANN operations and many other issues for which community input and advice is appropriate; Playing an important part in ICANN's accountability mechanisms; Coordinating some of ICANN's outreach and engagement efforts to individual Internet users.

Representative of Internet Society Hong Kong

You are the representative of Internet Society Hong Kong, an organisation driven by individual users and Internet professionals. Back in 2012, ISOC Hong Kong already recognized the trend and advantages of having new gTLDs, and believed that Hong Kong businesses would fall behind others if they missed the chance of applying new gTLDs. ISOC Hong Kong believes that new gTLDs would bring positive impacts to the Internet, promote innovation and reduce confusion with fake websites. However, new gTLDs are not your prioritized interest.

Due to the current political situation in Hong Kong, you concern more about the relations between cybersecurity and DNS abuse, and who will be the one to enforce the policies. You have concerns over pressures from government on private sector.

Representative of Internet users in Japan

You are one of the many Internet users in Japan. Use your own thoughts to express your own stand and opinions. You care about security of ISPs, hosting providers, DNS abuse or other abuses online. You care about issues like phishing, pharming and botnets, which are out of ICANN's purview.

Representative of Internet users in the U.S.

You are an Internet user in the United States. The United States is still a long way from finding a political consensus on the acceptable bounds of free speech and the best methods of protecting minors and police illicit Internet behaviour. Gambling and child pornography, for example, are hotly debated topics. Will there be any harm to the next generation if new gTLDs permit applications from people and non-governmental organisations?

Representative of Internet user in Arabic States

You are an average Arabic internet user. Access to high-speed fixed broadband remains extremely limited. The lack of an existing fixed-phone-line infrastructure makes expanding fixed broadband access more difficult. Policymakers and international organisations are increasingly focused on providing access to high-speed broadband. With the 2026 application window now closed and over 1,600 new strings awaiting evaluation, you must argue for strict safeguards during the upcoming delegation phase to protect vulnerable internet users from a potential surge in phishing and malware.

Position 1: ICANN should take action.

Position 2: Introduction of new gTLDs is more important.

Representative of Internet Society of China

You are the President of ISC, a group of 140 Chinese Internet industry members that includes commercial firms, schools, and research institutes. Chinese government agencies such as the Ministry of Information Industry, the Ministry of Education, and the State Council Information Office also promote ISC. Companies agree to identify and prohibit the dissemination of any content deemed unacceptable by Chinese authorities, such as information that "breaks laws or spreads superstition or obscenity," or that "may harm state security and undermine social stability."

Position 1: Align with stance of the Chinese Government but more focused on the technical aspects. Neutral towards prioritisation of either DNS abuse or new gTLDs.

Position 2: Supports ICANN-developed policies, but enforcement is under other authorities' jurisdiction.

**Note: Not affiliated in any way with global Internet Society*

Representative of Internet User in Afghanistan

You are an Islamic Internet user in Afghanistan. Islamic idea is prevalent in the country and becomes one of the internet policy. You are afraid of the open application of new gTLDs may infringe the rights of Muslim in Afghanistan. Western business may register the gTLD with discrimination on Muslim. You are considering whether religion can be one of the eligibility criteria in new gTLDs application.

You are more concerned about Internet connectivity and fundamental infrastructure on routing than new gTLDs.

Representative of Engineers

You are the representative of the Internet Engineering Task Force (IETF), which is a large open international community of network designers, operators, vendors, and researchers concerned with the evolution of Internet architecture and the smooth operation of the Internet. IETF is open to any interested individuals.

Position 1: You are a firm believer in net neutrality. Policies should be implemented into technical protocol so that it is governed fairly.

Position 2: Policies must account for users' errors, and therefore must be iterated on constantly.

Representative of youth initiative (NetMission)

You are the representative of NetMission Ambassadors, who support and engage a network community of young people including developing projects, policies and ideas to further the open and collaborative spirit of the internet. Ambassadors will empower and encourage others in advance and use a respectable and harmonious Internet environment for the benefit of all people in Asia and throughout the world.

Position 1: You support a multistakeholder approach and want to be involved in policy making in order to reflect youth's opinions equally as any other stakeholders.

Representative of NextGen@ICANN

You are the representative of NextGen@ICANN in which you have been engaging and contributing to the work that supports stability, resilience and reliability of the Internet due to the fact that you have been immersively furnished with knowledge pertaining to the technical governance of the Internet, Internet ecosystem, Internet governance, the multistakeholder model and policy development at ICANN.

Useful links

Meetings & Records

ICANN72 - Session 3 - DNS Abuse Mitigation

<https://gac.icann.org/sessions/icann72-session-3-dns-abuse-mitigation>

ICANN72 - Session 4 - GAC Meeting with the GNSO

<https://gac.icann.org/sessions/icann72-session-4-gac-meeting-with-the-gnso>

ICANN74 GAC Discussion: DNS Abuse

[https://74.schedule.icann.org/meetings/QqjSKJnn38qcv5Zv5#/?limit=10&sortByFields\[0\]=isPinned&sortByFields\[1\]=lastActivityAt&sortByOrders\[0\]=-1&sortByOrders\[1\]=-1&uid=messagesWidgetTable-QqjSKJnn38qcv5Zv5](https://74.schedule.icann.org/meetings/QqjSKJnn38qcv5Zv5#/?limit=10&sortByFields[0]=isPinned&sortByFields[1]=lastActivityAt&sortByOrders[0]=-1&sortByOrders[1]=-1&uid=messagesWidgetTable-QqjSKJnn38qcv5Zv5)

ICANN74 GNSO Council DNS Abuse Small Team Meeting

[https://74.schedule.icann.org/meetings/pQCgaeXGXGnd2MAmw#/?limit=10&sortByFields\[0\]=isPinned&sortByFields\[1\]=lastActivityAt&sortByOrders\[0\]=-1&sortByOrders\[1\]=-1&uid=messagesWidgetTable-pQCgaeXGXGnd2MAmw](https://74.schedule.icann.org/meetings/pQCgaeXGXGnd2MAmw#/?limit=10&sortByFields[0]=isPinned&sortByFields[1]=lastActivityAt&sortByOrders[0]=-1&sortByOrders[1]=-1&uid=messagesWidgetTable-pQCgaeXGXGnd2MAmw)

Transcripts

ICANN72 - Joint Meeting: GAC and the ALAC

<https://gac.icann.org/file-asset/public/icann72-gac-session-5-gac-meeting-with-the-alac-en-transcript.pdf>

Other resources

At-Large and DNS abuse

<http://atlarge.icann.org/policy/at-large-and-dns-abuse-en>

ICANN72 DNS Abuse Mitigation

<https://gac.icann.org/presentations/public/ICANN72%20-%20DNS%20Abuse%20Mitigation.pdf>

ICANN 73 DNS Abuse Mitigation

<https://gac.icann.org/presentations/public/DNS%20Abuse%20slides.pdf>

ICANN 74 DNS Abuse Mitigation

https://gac.icann.org/presentations/public/ICANN74%20-%20DNS%20Abuse%20Mitigation.pdf?language_id=1

Blog: ICANN72: DNS Abuse discussions shifting gears

<https://www.centri.org/news/blog/icann72-abuse.html>

ALAC Advice on DNS Abuse

https://atlarge.icann.org/advice_statements/13747

The roadmap: ccNSO & DNS Abuse

<https://ccnso.icann.org/sites/default/files/field-attached/roadmap-ccnso-dns-abuse-10mar22-en.pdf>

Link to Communiqués (72-74)

<https://gac.icann.org/topics/dnsAbuse>

Appendix 1 - What is DNS abuse?

DNS Abuse is any malicious activity aimed at disrupting the DNS infrastructure or causing the DNS to operate in an unintended manner. DNS Abuse is composed of five broad categories of harmful activity in so far as they intersect with DNS; malware, botnets, phishing, harming, and spam which serve as the delivery mechanisms for the DNS Abuse. (Contracted Party House (CPH), ICANN). This malicious activity on the Internet routinely threatens and affects domain name registrants and end-users by leveraging vulnerabilities and features of all aspects of the Internet and DNS ecosystems. When at scale, some of these nefarious activities may threaten the security, stability, and resiliency of the DNS infrastructures. These threats are generally referred to as DNS Abuse within the ICANN Community. (ICANN)

Abuse of the DNS: Traffic that causes DNS servers or intermediate architecture involved in the transmission or processing of DNS services, or both, to be degraded or unavailable to third parties, or that causes unintended results in the service provided by DNS service operators or registry service providers.

Abuse via the DNS: Harmful cyber activity that cannot take place without using the DNS, but where the threat actors' operations do not constitute abuse of the DNS. (ICANNWiki)

Five types of DNS Abuses from the CPH perspective

- **Malware** is malicious software, installed on a device without the user's consent, which disrupts the device's operations, gathers sensitive information, and/or gains access to private computer systems. Malware includes viruses, spyware, ransomware, and other unwanted software.
- **Botnets** are collections of Internet-connected computers that have been infected with malware and commanded to perform activities under the control of a remote administrator.
- **Phishing** occurs when an attacker tricks a victim into revealing sensitive personal, corporate, or financial information (e.g. account numbers, login IDs, passwords), whether through sending fraudulent or 'look-alike' emails, or luring end-users to copycat websites. Some phishing campaigns aim to persuade the user to install software, which is in fact malware.
- **Pharming** is the redirection of unknowing users to fraudulent sites or services, typically through DNS hijacking or poisoning. DNS hijacking occurs when attackers use malware to redirect victims to [the attacker's] site instead of the one initially requested. DNS poisoning causes a DNS server [or resolver] to respond with a false IP address bearing malicious code. Phishing differs from pharming in that the latter involves modifying DNS entries, while the former tricks users into entering personal information.
- **Spam** is an unsolicited bulk email where the recipient has not granted permission for the message to be sent and where the message was sent as part of a larger collection of messages, all having substantively identical content. While Spam alone is not DNS Abuse, we include it in the five key forms of DNS Abuse when it is used as a delivery mechanism for the other four forms of DNS Abuse. In other words, generic unsolicited e-mail alone does not constitute DNS Abuse, but it would constitute DNS Abuse if that email is part of a phishing scheme.
- This specific five-point definition was legally codified into ICANN's registrar and registry agreements during the April 2024 amendments

DNS abuse adjacent issues

- **Credential stuffing:** In order to gain access to a system, attackers use lists of compromised user credentials in a technique known as "credential stuffing". Based on the presumption that many users reuse usernames and passwords across various services, the attack automates and scales using bots.
- **Password spraying attacks:** Password spraying is an attack that attempts to access numerous accounts (usernames) with a few commonly used passwords. This is a type of brute force attack. In this attack, an attacker will brute force logins based on a list of usernames with default passwords.
- **Compromise of email accounts:** Email account compromise (EAC) is a highly sophisticated attack in which attackers infiltrate victims' email accounts in order to access valid mailboxes by using a variety of methods, including malware, phishing, and password spraying.
- **Password compromise:** The real-world passwords exposed in past data breaches. This exposure makes the passwords highly vulnerable and unsafe to use.
- **Poor password management:** Making poor password choices and then doubling down by using the same passwords over and over again can be identified as poor password management.
- **Insider credential theft and abuse:** Credential theft is a type of cybercrime that involves stealing a victim's proof of identity. Credential Theft occurs when malicious actors steal login details and use them to access.

DNS Abuse is one of the biggest challenges faced by individual Internet end users and remains a key factor eroding confidence in a single, trusted, interoperable Internet. Systemic abuse is a persistent problem; bulk registrations are a problem. (ALAC) "Protecting the public from security threats and DNS Abuse is an important public policy issue." (GAC) DNS refers to Intentionally deceptive, conniving, or unsolicited activities that actively make use of the DNS and/or the procedures used to register domain names by Competition, Consumer Trust, and Consumer Choice (CCT).

The CCT Team observed that Domain names are often a key component of cybercrime, are used to assist with malware distribution and botnet command-and-control and that spam campaigns often correlate with phishing and other cybercrime.

Appendix 2 - ICANN Bylaws & DNS

The mission of ICANN is to ensure the stable and secure operation of the Internet's unique identifier systems as described in this Section 1.1(a) (the "Mission"). Specifically, ICANN:

(i) Coordinates the allocation and assignment of names in the root zone of the Domain Name System ("DNS") and coordinates the development and implementation of policies concerning the registration of second-level domain names in generic top-level domains ("gTLDs"). ICANN's scope is to coordinate the development and implementation of policies such as

- registrar policies reasonably necessary to implement Consensus Policies relating to a gTLD registry;
- resolution of disputes regarding the registration of domain names (as opposed to the use of such domain names, but including where such policies take into account use of the domain names)

(ii) Facilitates the coordination of the operation and evolution of the DNS root name server system.

(iii) Coordinates the allocation and assignment at the top-most level of Internet Protocol numbers and Autonomous System numbers. In service of its Mission, ICANN (A) provides registration services and open access for global number registries as requested by the Internet Engineering Task Force ("IETF") and the Regional Internet Registries ("RIRs") and (B) facilitates the development of global number registry policies by the affected community and other related tasks as agreed with the RIRs.

(iv) Collaborates with other bodies as appropriate to provide registries needed for the functioning of the Internet as specified by Internet protocol standards development organisations. In service of its Mission, ICANN's scope is to provide registration services and open access for registries in the public domain requested by Internet protocol development organisations.

PDP. When ICANN and its constituencies create or change policies, the practices of the (PDP) Policy Development Process are followed. These practices aim to delineate an organisation's efforts in achieving its objectives, guideline generation, and how to structure relevant actions.

ICANN Policy Development Process. A key component of policy development from ICANN is the emphasis on consensus - seen as the best way to attract support and generate compliance throughout the entire global Internet community.

Work Products. PDP Updates are one-page documents prepared by ICANN staff to inform the Governmental Advisory Committee (GAC) and other interested parties about potential opportunities to engage in and contribute to ongoing GNSO PDP efforts.

Working Groups. The backbone of policy proposals and development, Working Groups or Work Parties consist of volunteer members, who can act as individuals or representatives of an organisation. They play a key role in the ratification of policies by engaging in dialogue and seeking consensus among their members.

Appendix 3 - 2024–2026 Policy & Program Updates

The landscape of ICANN policy and internet governance has evolved rapidly. To effectively role-play your stakeholder positions at the Model ICANN Conference, it is crucial to understand the following recent milestones, which have fundamentally shifted the debate surrounding DNS abuse, data privacy, and the expansion of the Domain Name System.

1. The 2024 DNS Abuse Contractual Amendments

Historically, combating DNS abuse was largely dependent on voluntary industry self-regulation. This changed when global amendments to the 2013 Registrar Accreditation Agreement (RAA) and the Base Generic Top-Level Domain Registry Agreement (RA) officially went into effect on April 5, 2024.

- **Mandatory Action:** Registrars and registries are now contractually obligated to promptly stop or otherwise disrupt domain names when they are presented with actionable evidence of DNS abuse.
- **Codified Definition:** The amendments officially codified the definition of DNS abuse into ICANN contracts, explicitly categorizing it as malware, botnets, phishing, pharming, and spam (when spam is used as a delivery mechanism for the other four forms).
- **Operational Requirements:** Contracted parties must now maintain dedicated abuse contacts, document their mitigation processes, and actively navigate the complexities of mandated disruptions without causing collateral damage to legitimate web traffic.

2. The 2025 Registration Data Policy (WHOIS)

The debate over WHOIS privacy—which was heavily disrupted by the European Union’s General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) and the subsequent redaction of personally identifiable information (PII)—reached a major milestone on August 21, 2025, with the implementation of the Registration Data Policy.

- **Permanent Framework:** This new consensus policy permanently replaces the Interim Registration Data Policy.
- **Standardized Rules:** It establishes a finalized, predictable framework for how domain registration data is collected, transferred, and published in compliance with global privacy laws.
- **Impact on DNS Abuse:** For stakeholders like the GAC, the debate is no longer about fighting the initial redaction of PII. Instead, arguments should focus on whether this finalized 2025 framework effectively balances the investigative needs of law enforcement and cybersecurity experts with the codified global privacy rights of registrants.

3. The 2026 New gTLD Round Timeline

The expansion of the internet through new Generic Top-Level Domains (gTLDs) has entered its next major phase, altering the timeline of the DNS abuse debate.

- **Application Window Closed:** The highly anticipated application window for the New gTLD Program: 2026 Round officially closed on August 12, 2026.

- **Volume of Applications:** ICANN received over 1,600 applications for new strings, with the community currently anticipating "Reveal Day" in October 2026 to review the applied-for names.
- **Shifted Debate:** The central argument is no longer about whether to delay the launch of the gTLD application window until DNS abuse is solved. Because the applications are already submitted, stakeholders must now debate what strict DNS abuse mitigation safeguards need to be finalized and enforced before these new strings are officially delegated to the root zone.

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